Chapter Forty-Four

Young Kings

Between 1227 and 1242,
Louis IX of France fights off Henry III of England,
and the kings of León-Castile and Aragon
almost finish the reconquest of Spain

THE WESTERN KINGDOMS were in the hands of the young.

In France, twelve-year-old Louis IX and his regent, his mother Blanche of Castile, faced a front of French barons who were tired of eclipse. Louis's grandfather, Philip Augustus, had taken a loose collection of almost-independent noble estates in Western Francia and turned them into France, a country united under a strong-handed king. France was more prosperous, stronger, larger than Western Francia had ever been.

The price: the power of France's nobility.

Philip Augustus's son Louis VIII, an experienced soldier, had died of dysentery in 1226 after a brief three-year reign. His untimely death gave the French aristocrats a chance to push back. "Since the barons of France saw the King a child," writes Louis's friend and biographer, the Crusader knight Jean de Joinville, "and the Queen his mother a foreign woman, they made the Count of Boulogne, the uncle of the King, their chief, and held him likewise